OBITUARY

An Unfailing Striving for Perfection

A. Ramachandran blazed a solitary trail while contributing immensely to the realm of art

By Yashodhara Dalmia

When the lush landscapes replete with verdant flora vanish, the creator of these, the artist A. Ramachandran (1935-2024), will remain forever in memory. In his passing away, we have lost not only a remarkable artist but also a visionary who ploughed his lonely furrow while contributing immensely to the world of art.

If in his early years, he depicted the hardships and struggles the ordinary man faced in his daily life, the vortex of despair transformed into the lyricism and grace of their existence. Ramachandran, with his voluptuous forms and brilliant colours, in later years travelled far from the angst of his earlier works but only to delve into the lustre of life.

Few understood, however, that in doing so, the artist was defining modernity in its own terms. He felt that to reveal the lucidity and lyricism of life was a way of constructing a modernism that was imbued with a vision more akin to not just his reality but also that of his fellow countrymen. As he stated in an interview with me some years ago, "There are two reasons for this: the situation which produces art in New York is not exactly the same as the situation in India. In spite of the fact that we have televisions and scientific knowledge, that alone does not justify a modern movement.... Any modernity that does not connect to our own 2,000 years of tradition cannot be modernity...."



A. RAMACHANDRAN (1935-2024)

Ramachandran's journey began in his home state Kerala, where he witnessed the murals on the walls of temples and was also enthralled by the Kathakali performances. It was only, however, after completing his studies at Santiniketan that the breakthrough came with paintings on the legend of Yayati made in the mid-'80s, which unfolds in contemporary times. In this narrative from the Mahabharata, the king of a ripe age asks his son to donate his youth to him so that he can enjoy worldly pleasures to the fullest. Ramachandran's unfolding painting is replete with lush flora, fauna and beautiful women where the lotus ponds that have traditionally symbolised the fecund, female aspect are an energising force.

The artist then began delving into the lore of the tribals of Rajasthan and while placing them in mythological time, he memorialised their rugged earthiness. The narrative of Urvashi and Pururavas unfolded in the '90s with the Bhil tribal as the protagonists and was meshed with tales from their lives. He stated, "As I said when I look at Gadia Lohar, it is the structure of their body, it is the complexion that can be transplanted into a certain kind of colour range. It's the kind of patterns that create a rhythm on the canvas surface..." The artist received the Padma Bhushan in 2005.

Ramachandran's apprenticeship with Ramkinkar Baij is by now legendary. He moved to Santinekatan in 1957 and imbibed a larger vision of art that related the entire environment in his work. When he went to Baij, the artist threw his sketchbook out of the window. In his words, "He ignored me for one and a half years.... I used to watch through the window because he was doing those maquettes of the Yakshis for the Reserve Bank building in Delhi." And slowly Ramachandran developed his own repertoire of sculptures. If there is something allegorical in this story, it also speaks of a mode of art linked to an unfailing striving for perfection.

A unique aspect of Ramachandran's work is that he also interposed his own portrait, half-man, half-animal symbolising a being who, as was known in ancient times, can metamorphose incessantly. Was this a playful way of saying that the artist's vision is equally changeable and multiple?

Ramachandran's synoptic overview included murals, intricate miniatures, etchings, sculptures and book illustrations, and he even designed stamps. He lived his life to the fullest and also spent most of his time in his artistic pursuits as well as engaging with human encounters, which were peppered with a sense of humour.

The vast array of bronze sculptures on display in Delhi last year was evidence of his sound workmanship, but also an astute vision which came with years of striving towards perfection. In passing away on February 10 at the age of 89 of a kidney ailment, he leaves behind a rich legacy that is not only replete with the fecundity of life but also the significance of his own experiential vision. ■

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